Benazir Bhutto's second premiership expired in November 1996, and Nawaz Sharif was returned to the top of Islamabad's slippery pole. Nawaz also strongly supported Taliban forces, Pakistan first granting its recognition to Mullah Omar's fundamentalist regime, then urging Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates to do the same. Had Nawaz and Benazir only been able to work together, trying to reconcile their personal differences and deep suspicions of each other, Pakistan might have been saved its prolonged return to military rule. But neither leader trusted the other, leaving both vulnerable to easy removal by the army. Nawaz believed Benazir to be India's tool on the question of Kashmir and was more reluctant himself to consider the idea of agreeing to treat the Line of Control as the Indo-Pakistani border. Obsessed as he became with fears of how soft Benazir was toward India, Sharif failed to realize that to Pakistan's ISI and its generals, he was also viewed as too weak to govern.

After the withdrawal of Soviet forces, Afghanistan reverted to a medieval state under Taliban-led tyranny. In Kashmir, a new era of insurgency and terror began, with cries of "Azaadi!" ("Freedom!") echoing across its beautiful valley and to the frozen top of the embattled Siachen Glacier.